

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Aquifer Open Study Notes

Lamentations 1:1–22

Chapter 1 mourns the destruction and desolation of Jerusalem, recognizing that this was God's well-deserved judgment on Israel's sins.

Lamentations 1:2

The lovers were the fertility deities, Baal and Asherah, who were worshiped by most people in Judah. Her friends were her military allies, notably Egypt, who was no match for Babylon ([Jer 37:5–11](#)).

Lamentations 1:3

The woman of [1:1](#) is the nation of Judah. • led away into captivity: This happened four times: 605 BC ([Dan 1:3–4](#)); 597 BC ([2 Kgs 24:12–16](#); [Jer 52:28](#); [Ezek 1:2–3](#)); 586 BC ([2 Kgs 25:5–7](#), [18–21](#); [Jer 39:5–10](#); [52:29](#)); and 581 BC ([Jer 52:30](#)).

Lamentations 1:4

Jerusalem (Hebrew *Zion*): In the Psalms and in the prophetic books, Zion represents the city of Jerusalem. In Lamentations, Zion is a poetic name for the city, even in ruins. [Hebrews 12:22–24](#) speaks of the heavenly Zion (see also [Rev 14:1–5](#)). • The annual festivals in Jerusalem were the Passover, Unleavened Bread, First Harvest, Harvest (Pentecost), Trumpets, the Day of Atonement, and Shelters (Tabernacles). • The main duties of the priests were carried out in the Temple and its surrounding area. Since the Temple was in ruins, they had no jobs and hence no future.

Lamentations 1:5

for her many sins: Judah's sins before the Babylonian invasion are outlined in [2 Kgs 21:1–9](#), [16](#); [24:3–4](#) (cp. [2 Chr 33:1–10](#), [22–23](#) and [2 Chr 36:11–16](#)). Similarly, a list of Israel's sins before Assyria destroyed it is found in [2 Kgs 17:14–23](#).

Lamentations 1:7

laughed as she fell: See also [Jer 24:9](#); [Ezek 22:5](#); [36:4](#).

Lamentations 1:8–9

Jerusalem was stripped of everything of physical and spiritual value that the people cherished.

Lamentations 1:10

For historical accounts of these events, see [2 Kgs 25:8–17](#); [2 Chr 36:13–21](#); [Jer 52:4–30](#).

Lamentations 1:13

The destruction of Jerusalem at the hands of the Babylonians was like fire from heaven.

Lamentations 1:14

For their sins, the people of Judah were tied to one another with ropes and taken as captives into exile.

Lamentations 1:15

his beloved city: God had given special care to Jerusalem, like a father protecting his daughter. But her sins had been persistent, and her punishment was horrible. • like grapes . . . trampled in a winepress: This common procedure for extracting juice from grapes is used vividly in [Isa 63:3](#) to show the horrors of punishment. In [Rev 14:18–20](#); [19:15](#), the image graphically represents universal judgment.

Lamentations 1:19

I begged my allies: Egypt had a great deal of interest in Judah because Judah controlled the only good route to the north. However, Egypt turned her

back on Judah when Babylon attacked Jerusalem ([Jer 37:5–11](#)). • When there was little rain in the fall and spring in Palestine, a summer without rain could destroy crops and cause a food shortage. The food supply also ran out under the prolonged siege of a city (Jan 588–July 586 BC), and many people starved to death ([2 Kgs 25:2–3](#); cp. [Jer 37:21](#)).

Lamentations 1:20

The leaders and people of Judah had rebelled ([Jer 2:17](#); [5:6](#), [23](#)) by rejecting the one true God and his commandments and by resisting the invaders God had sent ([2 Kgs 24:1](#), [20](#); [2 Chr 36:13](#)).

Lamentations 1:21

the day you promised: The poet's spirit was heartened by the belief that God would set up a day when everyone—oppressors and victims—would be judged justly (see [Isa 13:6](#), [9](#); [Jer 46:10–12](#), [27–28](#); [Amos 5:18–20](#); [Obad 1:15](#); [1 Thes 5:2–3](#); [2 Thes 2:2](#)).

Lamentations 2:1

the heights of heaven: Jerusalem's buildings were splendid, adorned with precious metals and jewels. Jerusalem had the reputation of being the sacred city of the Lord. • his Temple (literally *his footstool*): Cp. [1 Chr 28:2](#); [Pss 99:5](#); [132:7](#).

Lamentations 2:1–22

This chapter graphically portrays the Lord as Jerusalem's destroyer.

Lamentations 2:3–4

bends his bow: In the past, the Lord had been a mighty warrior on Israel's behalf (see [Exod 14:13–15:21](#); [Josh 23:9–11](#); [Judg 7](#); [2 Kgs 19:32–35](#)); now he waged war against Jerusalem (see [Isa 63:10](#); [Ezek 24:25](#)).

Lamentations 2:6

A garden shelter was a temporary structure that harvesters put up to provide shade. God had promised to take care of his Temple forever ([1 Kgs 9:3](#)), but now it seemed that he had abandoned it.

Lamentations 2:7

The Temple was destroyed because the sins that the priests and the people had committed within its walls had defiled its holiness (cp. [Jer 7:3–15](#); [26:3–6](#), [12–13](#); [Ezek 24:21](#)).

Lamentations 2:8

Ramparts were stone walls or mounds of earth built around a city to protect it from assault by an enemy army.

Lamentations 2:9

no more visions: Daniel and Ezekiel were prophets of the Lord who had visions while they lived among the exiles far from the land of Judah ([Ezek 1:1](#); [Dan 7:1](#)). This verse refers to prophets in Jerusalem who claimed to have visions that proved to be false.

Lamentations 2:10

Burlap (or *sackcloth*) was made of goat or camel hair and was often used for grain sacks or for items to be carried on pack animals. Poor people wore it as clothing because it was inexpensive, and people in mourning wore it as a sign of their deep sorrow (its dark color matched their mood, and its roughness matched their discomfort). • Throwing dust on their heads and clothing was a sign to neighbors that a family member had died.

Lamentations 2:13

Who can heal you? Reputed healers and prophets were all liars and frauds ([Jer 6:13–14](#)).

Lamentations 2:16

Their enemies were glad that Jerusalem was defeated.

Lamentations 2:17

promises . . . made long ago: God's promises of blessing were always contingent upon Israel's obedience to the law ([Deut 8](#)). He had promised to destroy them if they disobeyed it ([Lev 26](#)).

Lamentations 2:18–19

Repentance and prayer are the proper responses when facing the devastation of God's judgment.

Lamentations 2:20

Jeremiah had predicted that the same cannibalism that occurred during a siege of Samaria ([2 Kgs 6:28–29](#)) would happen in Jerusalem ([Jer 19:9](#); see also [Lam 4:10](#); [Ezek 5:10](#); cp. [Deut 28:53–57](#)).

Lamentations 2:22

calling them to a day of feasting: The poet compares Jerusalem's destruction to an invitation to a banquet at which war, famine, wild animals, and sickness would feast on the wicked in Jerusalem ([Deut 28:15–68](#); cp. [Rev 19:17–21](#)).

Lamentations 3:1–24

The author speaks of the suffering of Judah and Jerusalem as his own.

Lamentations 3:1–66

In this chapter, the author laments what has happened ([3:1–20](#), [48–54](#)), remembers the faithful love of the Lord ([3:21–25](#)), describes how God's people should respond ([3:26–47](#)), and calls upon the Lord in prayer ([3:55–66](#)).

Lamentations 3:6–9

Some understand these verses as a poetic reference to Jeremiah's confinement in a muddy cistern before the destruction of Jerusalem ([Jer 38:6–13](#)).

Lamentations 3:9

blocked my way . . . made my road crooked: Sin causes confusion and cuts a person or a community off from a happy future. Innocent people know the future as a straight path that is easy to follow ([Prov 21:8](#)). Isaiah imagined God's activities as a procession on a straight road that his worshipers would prepare ([Isa 40:3](#)).

Lamentations 3:12

Compare [Job 6:4](#).

Lamentations 3:19

is bitter beyond words (or *is wormwood and gall*): Wormwood is a plant with a bitter taste; here it represents the emotional intensity of inner agony ([Prov 5:4](#); [Rev 8:11](#)). Gall is a poisonous plant that causes severe physical pain if eaten; it is a powerful symbol for extremely stressful emotions ([Deut 29:18](#); [Ps 69:21](#)). The author seems to be at a dead end from which he cannot escape.

Lamentations 3:22

The faithful love of the Lord is the basis for the poet's recovery from deep depression. As with Jeremiah in the cistern ([Jer 38:6–13](#)) and Jonah in the stomach of the great fish ([Jon 2:2–10](#)), the Lord provided salvation from death.

Lamentations 3:22–33

God's love and faithfulness never cease. Just as God had been faithful in bringing judgment on Jerusalem for their sins, he would be faithful in bringing restoration to those who returned to him.

Lamentations 3:23

God's faithfulness speaks of his absolute reliability, which is evident in his daily mercies. He continually provides a habitable world in which we can live.

Lamentations 3:24

The Lord is my inheritance: The land of Canaan had been regarded as Israel's inheritance since the time of Moses ([Exod 15:17](#); [Josh 21:19](#); [1 Chr 28:8](#); [Ps 47:4](#)), but the true inheritance of God's people is really God himself (see [Ps 16:5-6](#); [Eph 1:11](#); [Heb 9:15](#); [1 Pet 1:3-4](#)).

Lamentations 3:26

Those who are confident of God's plan can wait quietly for him to grant salvation.

Lamentations 3:28

sit alone in silence: Humble submission stops the tongue and quiets the heart.

Lamentations 3:29-30

In the ancient Near East, lying face down in the dust expressed submission ([Gen 17:1-3](#); [Lev 9:24](#); [Josh 7:6](#); [1 Sam 5:4](#); [1 Kgs 18:39](#); [1 Chr 21:16](#); [Matt 17:5-6](#)). • To turn the other cheek also expresses submission. Jesus evidently had this verse in mind when he taught his disciples to submit to persecution ([Matt 5:39](#)). This response recognizes that God is sovereign even over our suffering.

Lamentations 3:31

Compare [Psalm 103:8-11](#).

Lamentations 3:34-36

The people of Judah were doing such things before Jerusalem was destroyed (see [Jer 5:26-31](#); [21:11-14](#); [23:10-14](#); [Mic 3](#)).

Lamentations 3:37-39

Some calamities have natural causes ([Luke 13:1-5](#)), and bad things happen to the righteous as well as to the wicked ([Matt 5:45](#)); whatever happens, we should give thanks ([1 Thes 5:18](#)) and not complain.

Lamentations 3:40-42

Repentance is the key to receiving salvation ([Isa 1:27](#); [Jer 3:22](#); [Ezek 3:21](#)).

Lamentations 3:48-66

The author focuses on the viciousness of the enemies and cries out to the Lord.

Lamentations 3:52-57

This passage might refer to Jeremiah's experience in the cistern ([Jer 37:11-15](#); [38:1-13](#)).

Lamentations 3:58-66

Jerusalem deserved punishment, but the enemies carried it out with undeserved cruelty. The writer calls upon God to punish them.

Lamentations 3:64-66

This prayer for vengeance is similar to several psalms (see "Prayers for Vengeance" Theme Note).

Lamentations 4:1-22

Although God's people still experience his judgment, they will soon experience restoration.

Lamentations 4:3

like ostriches: See also [Job 39:13-16](#).

Lamentations 4:7

like fine jewels: (literally *like lapis lazuli*): Lapis lazuli is a beautiful blue stone that is soft enough to carve. It is often used in decorations and mosaics.

Lamentations 4:8

Skin sticking to bones is symptomatic of the final stages of starvation, just before death.

Lamentations 4:9

Long sieges result in a serious lack of food. Even if people could get to the fields, they would find the crops destroyed or harvested to feed the soldiers.

Lamentations 4:12

Not a king . . . could march through the gates of Jerusalem: Since God had delivered Jerusalem from Sennacherib of Assyria more than a century earlier ([2 Kgs 19:36-37](#)), Judeans had strongly believed that not even the mightiest king, Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon, could defeat the city.

Lamentations 4:15

It appears that these leaders fled from Jerusalem as refugees to other lands.

Lamentations 4:20

Our king . . . was caught: A reference to Zedekiah, who tried to flee but was caught and treated cruelly by Nebuchadnezzar ([2 Kgs 25:4-7](#); [Jer 39:4-7](#); [52:9-11](#)).

Lamentations 4:21

Uz was an area east of the Jordan River that extended south to Edom. It was Job's home ([Job 1:1](#)).

Lamentations 4:21-22

The people of Edom were feeling secure and gloating over Jerusalem's misfortune, but they, too, would experience punishment for their sins (see [Obad 1](#); [Jer 49:7-22](#)).

Lamentations 4:22

The first return from exile occurred in 538 BC, after Cyrus of Persia defeated Babylon ([2 Chr 36:22-23](#); [Ezra 1:1-4](#)).

Lamentations 5:1-22

This chapter is a heartfelt prayer for restoration (cp. [Dan 9:4-19](#)).

Lamentations 5:10

There was a famine in the city during the siege ([2 Kgs 25:3](#); [Jer 37:21](#); [38:9](#); [52:6](#)).

Lamentations 5:12-17

These terrible things happened because the people had sinned (see [Isa 24:7-12](#); [Jer 7:24](#); [13:18](#); [25:10-11](#); [Amos 8:10](#)).

Lamentations 5:18

haunted by jackals: Cp. [Isa 13:22](#); [34:13](#); [Jer 9:11](#); [10:22](#); [Mal 1:3](#).

Lamentations 5:22

have you utterly rejected us? The tragedy of the Exile raised the question of whether God would forgive sin and restore his people. God answered clearly through the prophets ([Isa 40:27-31](#); [41:8-20](#)) and by sending Christ ([Matt 9:2-6](#); [26:28](#); [Luke 24:47](#)).